

Digging In

Confronted with a much more powerful adversary, the Viet Cong leveled their odds on the battlefield by taking the war underground.

◀◀ BEFORE

The Viet Cong drew upon their experience of fighting the French in the First Indochina War to help them confront US forces and the Saigon regime.

GOING UNDERGROUND

During the [First Indochina War](#), the Viet Minh relied on unconventional tactics and strategies to beat the French, also a more powerful opponent. These included building a complex network of **tunnels and bunkers** to conceal political and military operations, store weapons and supplies, and to shelter from bombs.

BOMBING THE TRAIL

South Vietnamese villages in the vicinity of the [Ho Chi Minh Trail](#) supply lines were particularly vulnerable to American bombing.

Vietnamese civilians and combatants—North and South—created thousands of miles of subterranean bunkers and passageways. Vietnam’s limestone and clay soil was relatively easy to excavate, but also stable enough to support large, permanent underground dwellings.

Bunkers became a standard part of Vietnamese homes, particularly in contested areas where bombs and artillery were a constant threat. For South Vietnamese civilians who actively supported the insurgency, home bunkers also served a military purpose: hiding rice, ammunition, and other supplies, and sheltering guerrilla fighters.

Underground community

In Vinh Moc, a village in the heavily fortified DMZ, local people took the bunker concept a stage further. Starting in 1966, they began building permanent underground quarters. Eventually, 60 families relocated underground, living in a network of tunnels more than a mile long, safe from US bombs and artillery. The village tunnels included rooms for every family, a larger room for community meetings and school lessons, kitchens with special stoves to vent the smoke, an infirmary, and several secret entrances, including some that opened onto the beach. Villagers lived this way for five years, going into the open only at night to farm their land or to ferry food and other supplies to Viet Cong guerrillas on Con Co island, a communist base about 15 miles (24 km) offshore.

The villagers of Vinh Moc claimed that they did not lose a single life to American bombs after they relocated underground. However, life in tunnels was very difficult. Inhabitants endured stinging insects, venomous snakes, malaria, intestinal parasites, food shortages, and vitamin D deficiency. Rats and cassava, a nutritious root vegetable that grew wild, were mainstays of the villagers’ diet. Tunnel dwellers also risked tunnel collapse, oxygen deprivation, and death or injury from bombs.